

Project Proposal

General Social Survey: <https://gss.norc.org/>

Project title: Does Education Equally Lift? The Asymmetric Returns of Educational Attainment on Class Status across Social Groups in the United States

Introduction Paragraph:

Is the promise that education changes one's destiny a lie? One of the dominant views in popular discourse suggests that education identifies and rewards the most capable individuals. The idea is so influential that it becomes part of the intrinsic values of society, granting solid legitimacy to the educational system. Yet in a country of over 343 million people, a college degree alone does not determine one's place in the social hierarchy, and its returns are far from uniform across social groups. While credentials may open doors, the extent to which educational attainment translates into higher subjective class identification appears to vary systematically by socio-economic factors like gender, race, and parental background. This project draws on data from the NORC General Social Survey (GSS, 2012–2024) to examine whether education's upward lift on class identity operates symmetrically across social groups in the United States, and what role income and social origin play in shaping this relationship.

Dataset Description:

The dataset used in this analysis comes from NORC at the University of Chicago's General Social Survey (GSS), a nationally representative survey conducted approximately every two years to measure social attitudes, behaviors, and demographic characteristics of people in the United States. Conducted since 1972 and funded by the National Science Foundation, the GSS tracks changes in American society over time. This project uses data from the 2012–2024 survey waves to capture pre-COVID-19 and post-COVID-19 fluctuations in responses. While the original dataset contains hundreds of variables and millions of observations, it was reduced for this project to 55 variables and 20,612 rows. The data consists primarily of categorical variables along with numerical and some text-based values. The dataset includes variables describing respondents' demographics, socioeconomic status, employment, education, family background, and political or social attitudes, including measures such as age, sex, race, income, wealth, occupation, education level, political ideology, perceptions of economic inequality, financial satisfaction, and views on social mobility. The General Social Survey data are publicly available for academic and research use through NORC at the University of Chicago, provided that the dataset is properly cited and used in accordance with the GSS data use guidelines.

Tentative Questions to Address:

1. **Patterns of Class Identification across Social Groups:** How does the distribution of subjective class identification vary across social groups at equivalent levels of educational attainment, and how has this pattern changed over time from 2012 to 2024?
2. **Predicting Class Identification by Social Characteristics:** What are the relative contributions of educational attainment, sex, income, and parental background in predicting an individual's subjective class identification, and does the predictive weight of education differ across social groups?

3. **Meritocratic Belief as a Moderator: Who Believes Effort Pays Off?** Do the factors predicting subjective class identification differ between respondents who believe individual effort determines success and those who attribute success to structural or external factors, and does this belief itself vary by social group and educational background? And to what extent does parental background shape the intergenerational transmission of meritocratic belief?

By answering these questions, we hope to recognize patterns that align with financial stability, which could be used by professional financial and career advisors to aid their clients in making informed decisions about their future based on their current situation.

Data Dictionary:

name	label
realinc	family income in constant \$
coninc	family income in constant dollars
hispanic	hispanic specified
uscitzn	is r us citizen
wordsum	number words correct in vocabulary test
ballot	ballot used for interview
wrkstat	labor force status
hrs1	number of hours worked last week
occ10	r's census occupation code (2010)
indus10	r's industry code (naics 2007)
marital	marital status
divorce	ever been divorced or separated
paocc10	father's census occupation code (2010)
paind10	father's industry code (naics 2007)
maocc10	mothers census occupation code (2010)
sibs	number of brothers and sisters
childs	number of children
age	age of respondent
educ	highest year of school completed
paeduc	Highest year school completed, father (or oldest same-sex parent)
maeduc	Highest year school completed, mother (or youngest same-sex parent)
degree	r's highest degree
padeg	Father's (or oldest same-sex parent's) highest degree
madeg	Mother's (or youngest same-sex parent's) highest degree
sex	respondents sex
race	race of respondent
reg16	region of residence, age 16

mobile16	geographic mobility since age 16
family16	living with parents when 16 yrs old
incom16	r's family income when 16 yrs old
born	was r born in this country
parborn	were r's parents born in this country
granborn	how many grandparents born outside u.s.
income	total family income
polviews	think of self as liberal or conservative
happy	general happiness
health	condition of health
life	is life exciting or dull
jobfind	could r find equally good job
rank	r's self-ranking of social position
satfin	satisfaction with financial situation
finalter	change in financial situation
finrela	opinion of family income
getahead	opinion of how people get ahead
parsol	r's living standard compared to parents
kidssol	r's kids living standard compared to r
masei10	r's mother's socioeconomic index (2010)
papres10	father's occupational prestige score (2010)
pasei10	r's father's socioeconomic index (2010)
prestg10	r's occupational prestige score (2010)
sei10	r's socioeconomic index (2010)
id_	Respondent id number
wtssps	person post-stratification weight
year	GSS year for this respondent
class_	subjective class identification